

It's a cat and mouse game that has been played over the years and is not a permanent solution, just a patchwork one."

Other experts say that when it comes to Iran's nuclear capabilities, one needs to look at essentially its hardware and software capabilities. The US and Israeli strikes would have damaged hardware installations like centrifuge halls to some extent. But with Iran developing its nuclear capability for over 40 years with huge amounts of investments and resources, its knowhow would not be diminished by these strikes or killing of a few nuclear scientists as Israel and the US had hoped for.

New Nuke Danger

Instead, Akbaruddin says, the real danger is that by targeting Iran's facilities, America may have lost oversight of Iran's nuclear programme because Tehran will now refuse IAEA monitoring and be opaque about its plans. Under the 1968 Non-Proliferation of Nuclear Weapons Treaty (NPT), the trade-off for receiving technology to develop nuclear reactors for peaceful means and desist from possessing nuclear weapons was that no other country would have the right to strike your open safeguarded facilities.

Israel, a nuclear weapons power that is not a signatory of the NPT, severely undermined its provisions when in June 1981 its air force bombed the Osirak research reactor that France had given Iraq. Then, in 2007, Israel used its air force jets to bomb a suspected nuclear research facility under construction at Al Kibar in Syria, claiming that North Korea was supplying the technology. That action seems to have pushed Syria to resort to making dangerous chemical weapons instead. As for Iran's nuclear programme, prior to 2025, Israel, backed by the US, used covert means to undermine Tehran's nuclear quest, including allegedly introducing a computer worm called Stuxnet into equipment at its Natanz facility in 2007 that caused centrifuges to self-destruct.

However, this time, with the US, the principal initiator and one of the depositaries of the NPT (with whom the instruments of ratification and accession are kept), joining Israel in bombing Iran's nuclear infrastructure, the compact not to carry out strikes against facilities under IAEA safeguards seems to have been broken. The fault lines that dogged the NPT have come to the fore. So, countries like Iran could be tempted to follow the model North Korea did—join the NPT, then go rogue and develop nuclear bombs. "The issue," says Akbaruddin, "is whether the US wanted to employ bunker busters or pursue diplomatic solutions. It chose the former and now the jury is out on whether it will pay you the dividend diplomacy did under Barack Obama."

During Obama's second term as president, the US along with the other P-5 countries—Russia, China, France and the UK—and Germany entered into an agreement with Iran called the Joint Comprehensive Plan of Action (JCPOA) in July 2015. Under it, Iran agreed to dismantle much of its nuclear programme and open its facilities for more extensive international inspections in exchange for billions of dollars of sanction relief. The idea was to degrade Iran's nuclear programme to the point that if Tehran decided to develop nuclear weapons, it would take at least a year, allowing the world powers to mount tough measures in the interim.

Under the deal, Iran agreed not to produce highly enriched uranium or plutonium that could be used for nuclear weapons and allowed the IAEA unfettered access. It also reduced its stockpile of highly enriched uranium by 97 per cent—from 10,000 kg to 300 kg. Trump, however, was dead against the deal, as he believed the removal of sanctions saw Iran's economy boom without deterring it from its secret intention to build nuclear weapons. After Trump became president in 2017, he pulled out of the agreement in May 2018 and imposed heavy sanctions on entities that did business with Iran.



AP

US-ISRAEL STRIKES MAY HAVE DESTROYED SOME OF THE HARDWARE AT THE BOMBED SITES BUT NOT THE KNOWHOW THAT IRAN HAS BEEN BUILDING OVER THE PAST 40 YEARS